



*Hera, Athena, and Aphrodite each tried to convince Paris to pick them.*

All three goddesses pleaded with Paris to choose them and promised him great rewards. “I can make you king of the entire world,” Hera said; “I can make you the most powerful warrior in all the land,” promised Athena; “I will let you marry the most beautiful woman on Earth,” Aphrodite announced.

Paris was a romantic at heart, and he could not say no to Aphrodite’s offer, so he handed the shining fruit to her. Aphrodite had won the contest, while Paris had won the hand of Helen, queen of Sparta.

*Helen was the most beautiful woman in the world.*



*Paris and Helen ran away in the night.*

Helen was, unfortunately, already married. The gods cared very little for the lives of mortals, and Aphrodite had ignored this fact when she promised Helen to Paris. The goddess went with the prince to the city of Sparta where Helen lived. Paris waited until Helen’s husband, Menelaus, was away, then went to find her. Helen was surprised by the arrival of the Trojan prince, but Aphrodite made sure she instantly fell in love with him. In the middle of the night, they sneaked away together.

When Menelaus returned to Sparta and discovered that Paris had stolen his wife, he